

Back-rank mates

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



The defending king is on h8. Geometrically undefended: rook on f8 and knight on g4. Check for tactical protection.



23. Rxf8#

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on f8. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

A flight square, an interposition, or a countercheck may refute an apparent mate. Check all three before sacrificing material.